



OFF-SIDE

Ayon Sengupta

sportstar@thehindu.co.in



WHAT THE YEAR TOOK, WHAT IT GAVE

2025 closed familiar chapters in Indian sport, tested transitions across games, and quietly offered renewal, **most notably** through women's teams and emerging athletes.

As the year draws to a close, it's time to take stock of India's sporting achievements in 2025. There were seismic shifts at the very top. The long chapter of Rohit Sharma and Virat Kohli as India's multi-format mainstays came to a close, marking the end of an era that defined a generation of Indian cricket. New stars emerged too, most suitably in the shortest format. Abhishek Sharma, honed under the watchful eyes of another marauder, Yuvraj Singh, broke every conceivable record in T20 cricket as India readied itself for a world title defence at home.

Change, however, is never gentle. The transition in red-ball cricket was far from smooth, with India suffering a second home Test series whitewash in less than a year. In football, the men's game sank to its nadir, lurching from one indignity to another and forcing uncomfortable questions about structure, vision and accountability. Questions that, for now, seem to have no answers from the wise men who run the game.

And yet, sport has a way of restoring balance. If the men faltered, the women carried the nation's hopes with grace and grit. The Indian women's cricket team lifted its maiden ICC trophy, a triumph years in the making. In football, three Indian women's teams qualified for their respective continental showpieces, offering hope from a direction often overlooked.

Success came in other disciplines as well. Hockey enjoyed a vintage year with an Asian Cup win and strong junior World Cup showings, underlining its continued revival. In boxing, Jaismine Lamboria's breakthrough stood out as a statement from the new generation. In shooting, Samrat Rana and Suruchi Singh delivered

under pressure, proving that India's talent pipeline continues to regenerate.

Track and field, too, had its moments. Neeraj Chopra finally shattered the mythical 90-metre barrier, exorcising a hoodoo that had loomed large over Indian athletics. And just as importantly, Sachin Yadav snapping at his heels signalled that competition — the lifeblood of progress — is alive and well.

Beyond the mainstream, kabaddi continued to excel as the women's team won the World Cup in Dhaka, while the women's blind cricket team delivered a stirring, inspiring performance in Sri Lanka.

At *Sportstar*, we tried to be where sport was actually happening. On the field, in the dressing rooms, in boardrooms, and sometimes in uncomfortable places where questions needed to be asked. We told stories of triumph and transition, of systems working and systems failing, of athletes who soared and those who struggled. Some of you loved our work. Some of you didn't.

Both responses keep us honest. Our effort, always, is to live up to every expectation and to do better when we fall short.

If 2025 was eventful, 2026 promises to be relentless. With the Hockey India League, the WPL, the IPL, the ICC Men's T20 World Cup, the ICC Women's T20 World Cup, the FIFA World Cup, the men's and women's Hockey World Cups, the Asian Games and the Commonwealth Games — alongside the familiar spectacles of the Grand Slams, Formula 1 and bilateral cricket — the first 10 months of the year promise to make every month feel like a festival of sport.

Here's wishing you a great year ahead, and a truly unforgettable sporting year.